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Critical Journalism and the Courage to Lead

Presentation by Churchill Otieno, President, The Africa Editors Forum (TAEF) during the opening of the Uganda Editors Convention on July 31, 2026 in Jinja.

It is an honour to join the Uganda Editors Guild at a convention whose theme, **Media Viability in the Digital Age**, could not be more timely. Over the next few days you will discuss elections, sustainability, regulation, AI, newsroom safety and the future of journalism. These are not separate conversations. Together, they define the future of our profession.

Across Africa, journalism is under pressure like never before. Political pressure has intensified. Economic pressure has become existential. Technology has disrupted business models built over generations. Artificial intelligence is changing how information is created, distributed and consumed.

Yet the greatest threat to journalism has never been technology. It has always been power that fears accountability.

Independent journalism has never been welcomed by the powerful. Not by kings, not by colonial administrations, not by dictators, and not by modern governments. History reminds us that power has always preferred praise to scrutiny. That is precisely why journalism exists.



It exists to ask difficult questions. It exists to hold power accountable. It exists to ensure citizens know enough to govern themselves.

That is why the recent closure of Nation Media Group's outlets in Uganda should concern every citizen, not just journalists.

If any media house violates the law, Uganda already has legal and regulatory mechanisms to address those grievances. Democracies are strengthened when disputes are resolved through institutions, not through the silencing of institutions.

Those who ordered or celebrated the closure may consider it a demonstration of strength, even heroism. It is neither. In truth, it diminishes Uganda.

Because every time an independent newsroom is silenced, citizens lose another avenue through which truth can reach them. A country cannot become stronger by narrowing the space for information. It becomes weaker.

To our colleagues in Uganda, I therefore say this: Do not confuse difficult times with hopeless times. The work you do has never been more necessary.

But courage alone is no longer enough.

Editors must become institution builders. We must protect editorial independence, prepare our newsrooms for AI, mentor the next generation, build sustainable business models, and defend ethical journalism even when it is commercially inconvenient.



The future belongs not to the loudest voices, but to the most credible ones.

Africa does not need more content. Africa needs more trusted journalism. And trusted journalism begins with courageous editors. So lead with integrity. Lead with wisdom. Lead with imagination. Challenge governments when necessary. Challenge yourselves always.

Collaborate more than you compete. Our greatest responsibility is not simply to publish tomorrow's headline. It is to ensure that future generations inherit societies where truth still matters.

I have every confidence that Uganda's editors will continue to stand for that ideal.

And when history writes this chapter, may it say that in an age of pressure, intimidation and uncertainty, Africa's editors did not retreat.

They led.

Thank you, and I wish you fruitful deliberations.



About The African Editors Forum (TAEF)

The Africa Editors Forum (TAEF) is a continental network of editors, senior newsroom leaders, and media executives committed to strengthening independent journalism and advancing media freedom across Africa. TAEF works to promote ethical standards, defend press freedom, deepen professional solidarity, and support editorial innovation in response to the evolving political, economic, and technological landscape shaping the continent. Through convenings such as the Africa Editors Congress and strategic partnerships with regional and global institutions, TAEF provides a platform for dialogue on journalism's role in democracy, development, and

À propos du Forum des éditeurs Africains (TAEF)

Le Forum des éditeurs africains (TAEF) est un réseau continental d'éditeurs, de responsables de rédaction et de dirigeants de médias, engagé à renforcer le journalisme indépendant et à promouvoir la liberté de la presse en Afrique. Le TAEF promeut des normes éthiques, défend la liberté de la presse, renforce la solidarité professionnelle et soutient l'innovation éditoriale face aux évolutions politiques, économiques et technologiques du continent. À travers des rencontres comme le Congrès des éditeurs africains et des partenariats avec des institutions régionales et internationales, le TAEF offre une plateforme de dialogue sur le rôle du journalisme dans la démocratie, le développement et l'affirmation de l'agence africaine. Le Forum défend

African agency in emerging domains. The Forum also champions fair compensation for journalism as a public good, newsroom resilience in the digital age, and collaborative responses to threats facing journalists and media organisations. TAEF serves as a collective voice for Africa's editors, advancing a journalism culture rooted in independence, public interest, and lasting excellence.

une rémunération équitable du journalisme en tant que bien public, la résilience des rédactions à l'ère numérique et des réponses collectives aux menaces visant les journalistes et les médias. Le TAEF se positionne comme la voix collective des éditeurs africains, promouvant une culture journalistique fondée sur l'indépendance, l'intérêt public et l'excellence durable.